PROJECT PROPOSAL

Otithi

A Homestay Platform for Remote-Area Tourism in Bangladesh

> **PROJECT GOAL**
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> Travellers visiting remote villages and hill areas of Bangladesh often find nowhere to stay, because no hotel exists there and no booking website covers these places. At the same time, local families in those villages have spare rooms and guest rooms that remain empty. Otithi is a website where local families can list their available rooms and travellers can find and book them directly — creating accommodation where none currently exists, and income for the families who provide it.

1. Problem

Hotel booking websites only cover cities and a few major tourist spots. Anyone travelling to a village, a hill area or a riverine region has no way to find a place to stay in advance. They either cancel the trip, return the same day, or arrive and hope to find something.

The rooms, however, already exist. Many rural families have an unused guest room. There is simply no way for a traveller to know it exists, and no way for the family to let anyone know.

2. Main Features

01 Honest Room Condition Checklist

Before a room is published, the host must answer a short set of fixed questions about the real condition of the stay. These answers are shown on the listing beside the photos.

Toilet	Attached · Outside · Shared
Electricity	Steady · Load-shedding common · Solar only
Water	Tap · Tubewell · Pond
Mobile network	Good · Weak · None
Bedding	Provided · Bring your own
Road access	Vehicle reaches house · Short walk · Long walk

> **WHY THIS MATTERS:** Normal booking sites hide unattractive details because honesty reduces bookings. Here, disclosure is compulsory. A guest who knows in advance about an outside toilet arrives satisfied; a guest who discovers it on arrival does not. This solves the most common reason rural homestays go wrong.

02 Directions by Landmark, Not Address

Remote villages have no proper address. Instead of an address field, each host writes simple directions in their own words, such as: "*From Jaflong Bazar, take a CNG toward Sangrampunji, get down at the blue mosque, walk five minutes north — white tin-roof house beside the mango tree.*" The listing also records the nearest landmark and nearest bazar.

> **WHY THIS MATTERS:** Every booking website assumes a street address and a map location exist. In rural Bangladesh they do not, which is one reason these areas are not covered by any platform. Otithi follows the way people in villages actually give directions.

03 Browse by Village, Not by Single Room

Listings are grouped by village. Opening a village shows all the host families in that village together, with the number of households and total rooms available.

This means a group of six or eight travellers can stay in two or three neighbouring houses in the same village, which a single-room listing cannot handle.

> **WHY THIS MATTERS:** In a village, no single house can take a large group, but three houses together easily can. Grouping by village makes group travel possible in places where it otherwise is not.

04 Verification on Both Sides

The host is letting a stranger stay in their family home, so verification works in both directions. Hosts submit identity documents and are approved by the admin before their room appears. Guests must also be verified before they can send a booking request.

After a stay, the guest reviews the host and the host also reviews the guest. A host can see a guest's past reviews before deciding to accept.

> **WHY THIS MATTERS:** Normal booking sites only check the property owner and treat the guest as a customer. When the room is inside someone's family home, that is not enough — the host needs to feel safe too.

05 Safety and Household Information

Each listing clearly states whether the family lives in the same house, whether female family members are present, whether there is a separate entrance, and whether the household is suitable for a solo female traveller or for a family with children. Travellers can filter by these.

> **WHY THIS MATTERS:** For women travelling alone and for families, this is the information that decides whether they go at all — and no accommodation website in Bangladesh shows it.

06 Cash Payment Directly to the Host

The website does not handle any money. When a host accepts a request, the system generates a short booking code. The guest shows this code on arrival and pays the host directly in cash. The host then marks the stay as completed.

> **WHY THIS MATTERS:** Rural families have no merchant accounts and would not trust an unknown website with their money. Keeping the platform out of payment removes the main reason such families would refuse to join, and means they receive the full amount with no commission deducted.

3. How It Works

1. A local family registers as a host and submits their identity documents.
2. The admin verifies them and approves the account.
3. The host adds their room with photos, price, the condition checklist and landmark directions.
4. A traveller searches by district and village and opens a listing.
5. The traveller sends a booking request for specific dates.
6. The host accepts, and the system issues a booking code.
7. The traveller arrives, shows the code and pays the host in cash.
8. After the stay, both sides leave a review.

4. Supporting Features

For Travellers	Description
Search and filter	Browse by district and village; filter by date, number of guests, price and room condition.
Listing page	Photos, price, room details, condition checklist, directions, house rules and reviews.
Booking request	Choose dates and number of guests and send the request to the host.
My bookings	Upcoming, completed and cancelled stays, with the booking code.
Reviews	Rate the stay and say whether the condition checklist was accurate.
Saved rooms	Keep a shortlist for later.

For Hosts	Description
Registration	Sign up as a host and submit documents for admin approval.
Add room	Room details, photos, price, capacity, condition checklist, directions and house rules.
Availability	Mark the dates on which the room is not available.
Booking requests	See incoming requests with the guest's review history, then accept or decline.
Booking history	Past guests, nights hosted and total income earned.

For Admin	Description
Verify hosts	Review and approve host identity documents.
Approve listings	Check new rooms before they become visible.
Manage locations	Maintain the district and village list.
Handle reports	Review complaints from either side.
Statistics	Number of hosts, bookings, districts covered and income generated.

5. Who Benefits

Group	Benefit
Travellers	Can find a confirmed place to stay in areas that have no hotels, and know the real conditions before going.
Women and families	Can see household and safety information in advance and choose accordingly.
Groups	Can stay together in one village across several neighbouring houses.
Rural families	Earn income from a room that was otherwise unused, with no commission taken.
Remote districts	Become reachable for tourism, because accommodation finally exists there.

6. Scope

The project covers domestic travel within Bangladesh only. The website is for listing rooms, searching and requesting bookings — it does not process online payments, since payment is made directly to the host in cash. Room conditions and details are provided by the hosts themselves and verified by the admin before publication.

> **CONCLUSION**
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> Otithi is not a hotel booking website for villages. It is built around the actual conditions of remote Bangladesh — no addresses, unreliable electricity and network, no merchant accounts, and hospitality that belongs to a village rather than a business. Each of its main features exists because one of those conditions makes an ordinary booking website unusable. Together they make it possible for a traveller to have somewhere to sleep in places where, today, there is nothing at all.